Rifles JCO, Prasad decided it would be more prudent to fall back to the junction of the Nam Ka Chu and the Rongla Nullah. The location they agreed on was sited on a spur, set back 400 metres from the Nam Ka Chu. As far as Assam Rifles posts were concerned, Dhola—as it would henceforth be known—was reasonably well sited from a strategic point of view. Any Chinese activity on the Thagla Ridge could be observed and if the Chinese were to come down the slope, they would be caught on the Nam Ka Chu. Leaving the Assam Rifles to set up the post on 4 June 1962, Captain Mahabir Prasad returned to Tawang where he submitted his report to the Assam Rifles. Incredible as it may seem, he was never debriefed by either Brigadier Dalvi or by 7 Infantry Brigade.

Dhola was the westernmost Indian post and as it lay in disputed territory. It was to be supported by a company that was to be located at Lumpu, separated from the Nam Ka Chu Valley by Hathung-la and Karpo-la, the two passes on the Tsangdhar Ridge. For three months the Chinese did not react, but in early September, the IB reported that the Chinese had occupied the Thagla Ridge.

Despite the MEA having green-lit the setting up of a post at Dhola, the DMO, Brigadier Palit, was not sure of the status of the region. He consulted Dr S. Gopal (the son of the then President of India, Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan) who was the director of the Historical Section of the MEA. Gopal explained to Palit that at the time of the boundary talks with China in 1954, the Government of India was aware that there was some ambiguity in the area of the tri-junction. The depiction on the quarter inch scale map differed from the actual ground position, so the Chinese were given the latitude and longitude reference (91° 40’ East, 27° 40’ North).

Gopal then made a noting on the file carried by Palit. ‘This point was further north of the tri-junction shown on our maps and nearer the point suggested by Army Headquarters. Furthermore, the Chinese had been told that the alignment followed Thagla Ridge, which is also the ridge shown by Army Headquarters in the sketch.’ The DMO put this down in the form of a note to HQ Eastern Command and sent it off and, amazingly, did nothing more about it even after the situation escalated dramatically in the next few days. Later, somewhat meekly defending his inaction on this critical bit of information, Palit was to say, ‘Dr Gopal never told me the Chinese did not accept our argument in 1954 and had, in fact, claimed the Thagla and Khenzemane to be on the northern side of the McMahon Line.’